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-:FOR UPSC IAS ASPIRANTS:-

"AVOID POLITICAL & IRRELEVANT ARTICLES"

Please Try To Read This Completely in 40 Minutes If You

Can't So Then You Have To Increase Your Efforts

All the topics of this UPSC IAS Edition are directly or

indirectly important for the prelims & main examination.

There are some topics which can be coded in answer writing

of other topics in the main exam.

HOLD TALKS ON G7 SUMMIT SIDELINES, FIRST MEETING IN OVER A YEAR

Trade to sailor safety, Modi and Trump look to turn a new page

Ties never as close, says US President; PM commends his efforts to end West Asia crisis

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 17

IN THEIR first meeting in over a year following the strain in bilateral ties, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump Wednesday walked the tightrope, projecting a positive path ahead with a trade deal soon, a strategic commitment to security, and remarks that rekindled hopes of skilled Indian professionals.

The meeting, on the sidelines of the G7 summit at Evian-Bains in eastern France, lasted 55 minutes, according to sources.

Following the talks, Modi said, "Pleased to meet President Trump in Evian. We reviewed the sustained progress

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



PM Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump hold bilateral talks on the sidelines of G7 Summit in Evian, France, Wednesday. ANI

Global South shouldn't be left to bear war burden, needs financial backing: PM to G7

Asks leaders to consider economic corridor, skilled mobility partnership

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 17

ister Narendra Modi Wednesday told G7 leaders, including US President Donald Trump, that the "most vulnerable countries" should not be left to bear the burden of these crises alone, and global financial organisations should develop support systems for af-

UNDERLINING THAT disruptions in fuel, fertiliser and food supply chains caused by the war in West Asia will impact the Global South for "a considerable period", Prime Min-

ECONOMY

UK-INDIA TRADE PACT TO COME INTO FORCE FROM JULY 15 [PAGE 13](#)

E.

EXPLAINED

Bridging the divide

fects nations.

The war in West Asia has adversely impacted the economy of India and other developing countries in Asia, Africa and Latin America as supply of

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India has taken the lead in articulating the concerns of the Global South comprising the developing, emerging and least developed nations in Asia, Africa, Latin America and Oceania, more so during its G20 Presidency in 2023.

HC to hear today Telegram plea over blocking order; shocking material: Govt

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, June 17

A DAY after it was blocked temporarily by the Centre ahead of the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination on June 21, messaging application Telegram challenged the government move before the Delhi High Court Wednesday and said it had received another order warning of action over "non-compliance" with the directive.

The bench of Justice Tejas Karia, which issued notice to the Centre with the liberty to file a reply and supporting documents, will hear the matter Thursday.

In its petition, Telegram sought quashing of the blocking order and, for the interim, a stay. It has been blocked until June 22.

The Centre, represented by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, told the bench there was "shocking material" on the platform. "We shudder to imagine a situation where there is public unrest," he said.

Accusing Telegram of not disclosing certain material

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THE WORLD [PAGE 12](#)

KEY POINTS OF DRAFT TEXT ON U.S.-IRAN DEAL

QS rankings: IIT-Delhi tops India list for 2nd yr, climbs to 118 globally

• TOP 10 IN COUNTRY

National Rank	2027 Global Rank	2026 Global Rank	Institute
1	118	123	IIT Delhi
2	134	129	IIT Bombay
3	170	180	IIT Madras
4	205	215	IIT Kharagpur
5	221	222	IIT Kanpur
5	221	219	IISc Bangalore
7	322	328	Delhi University
8	335	339	IIT Roorkee
9	349	334	IIT Guwahati
10	452	503	Shoolini University*

*BIOTECHNOLOGY AND MANAGEMENT SCIENCES

Vidheesha Kuntamalla
New Delhi, June 17

FOR THE second consecutive year, IIT-Delhi ranked highest among Indian institutions in the QS World University Rankings 2027, climbing five places

to 118th globally — the highest ever for an Indian institution, first achieved by IIT-Bombay in the 2025 rankings.

IIT-Bombay, which topped the country's list in the past, dropped from 129 to 134. Last

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Modi & Trump

in our bilateral cooperation in trade, energy, defence, technology and people-to-people ties.”

“Conveyed India’s appreciation on the progress in the efforts for restoring peace and stability in West Asia. Keeping the Strait of Hormuz open is vital for the global economy. Reiterated the importance of ensuring the safety and security of civilians, including seafarers.”

The leaders, according to Ministry of External Affairs spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal, reviewed the significant progress achieved under the “India-US COMPACT, including in defence, trade, energy and people-to-people ties”.

“Both sides reiterated their commitment to continue working together to advance the India-US Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership for the benefit of peoples of both countries and to promote peace, stability and prosperity in the Indo-Pacific and beyond,” Jaiswal said.

While Modi flagged India’s concerns over the Strait of Hormuz and the safety of its seafarers, Trump appeared conciliatory and measured on hot-button issues ranging from the long-pending trade deal to the mobility of Indian professionals headed to the US.

Reiterating that he stopped eight wars, Trump was careful not to mention Pakistan or its leadership given Indian sensitivities. Bilateral ties, strained by Trump’s claim of brokering the India-Pakistan ceasefire in May 2025 post Operation Sindoor, a claim Delhi rejected, dived after he imposed heavy tariffs on India including a penalty for

buying Russian energy. The preliminary framework for the bilateral trade deal could be reached only in February this year.

Responding to questions, Trump did not express regret on the loss of Indian lives during the West Asia conflict, including the death of three Indian seafarers in a US Navy missile attack, but his remarks were in sharp contrast to what the US State Department had said on the call between US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar – it had quoted Rubio saying “violations of the US blockade and the illicit transport of Iranian oil will not be tolerated”. This had led to a row in India.

Asked if he had any words of condolence for the grieving families of the Indian sailors who died, Trump said, “Yeah, I do. I heard about that. It’s a rough profession, there’s no question about it. And we work together on it. This has been happening throughout time, but we work together. We love, we love all of those people, they are great people.”

Underlining that relations between the two countries were never as close, Trump said they were close to concluding a trade deal. He called Modi a “tough” negotiator.

Pointing at Modi, he said, “He’s the most beautiful looking man. He looks so nice. He’s like an angel, but actually he’s a killer. I don’t want to use that word, killer. He’s as tough as they come, but he looks so good. So he gets you by surprise.”

“There’s few people like this. People say he’s such a nice man.

I said he’s very tough. He’s a tough trader, and he loves the Indian people, but he also loves the USA. We had Howdy Modi in Houston, remember, that was great.” He recalled people in thousands at the Ahmedabad stadium when he visited India in February 2020.

Asked about his possible visit to India for the summit of the Quad leaders, he said, “We will be going to India sometime in the future.”

On the West Asia crisis, Modi commended Trump for the progress made in the efforts to restore peace. “Thanks to your efforts, Mr President, new hope for peace and stability in the region has been rekindled, and I am confident that this will lead to long standing peace in the region. President, you and I agree that keeping the Strait of Hormuz open is vital for the global economy.”

“India has consistently emphasised the importance of ensuring freedom of navigation, and we should work together and place a particular emphasis on maritime trade... Indian seafarers in hundreds of thousands are working and performing their duties across global maritime trade routes, including the Strait of Hormuz, and their safety is of utmost importance to us. You made tremendous efforts towards reaching this understanding and this agreement, and I am confident that the issue of seafarers will receive the highest priority during the implementation of this agreement,” he said.

Responding to a question on whether he expects India to play any role in West Asia, Trump said, “Yeah, I do. I do. I think India plays a big role in everything, as long as he (Modi) is the leader.”

He even pledged to defend India in case of an attack. Perhaps mindful of the interpretation of his statement on defending India militarily, he also spoke about his “great meeting” with Chinese President Xi Jinping.

On the defence relationship between India and the US, he said, “I think it’s a great relationship. I can tell you this without having a contract. We don’t have a contract, but if they were attacked, we would be there to help them.”

“If anybody attacks that man (Modi), we’re going to be there. I’m not sure if there’s a new leader, I don’t know about that, if they’re attacked and he’s the leader, we’re going to be there now,” he said.

“I will say this, and everybody says it. I had a great meeting three weeks ago with President Xi of China. We have the strongest military in the world by far, and I built it in my first term, and we are using it in my second term, and they gave some of it away stupidly in Afghanistan, as you know, and they spent a lot on Ukraine, \$350 billion. But we have the most powerful military in the world. You saw that with Venezuela, which was 48, think of it, 48 minutes, and now our relationship with Venezuela is great. We paid for the cost of the war 40 times, taking millions of barrels out. Venezuela’s benefiting, we are benefiting... Then we go to Iran, and really, in the first week, militarily, we defeated Iran. Nobody thought that could be done.”

On questions regarding more opportunities for highly skilled Indian professionals, he said, “Oh, yeah, sure. I mean, always. We have always had tremendous relationships in terms of employment with India, very talented people.”

Global South

LPG, LNG, diesel, petrol and fertilisers have been disrupted by the near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz. This has led to rise in fuel prices with cascading effects on the economy, causing hardships.

Addressing the outreach session on ‘Reviving a Balanced, Shared and Sustainable Economic Growth for All’ at the G7 summit in Evian-les-Bains in France, Modi said, “The disruptions in fuel, fertiliser and food supply chains caused by the crisis in West Asia will continue to impact the Global South for a considerable period. If we genuinely seek to strengthen international solidarity, the most vulnerable countries should not be left to bear the burden of these crises alone.”

“Our international financial institutions should develop support mechanisms that help developing countries absorb these shocks and maintain their economic resilience,” he said.

Also attending the summit are the World Bank, IMF, OECD and African Development Bank.

Modi, who was articulating the concerns of the Global South, had said a day earlier that this bloc had “high expectations of the international community” and “what they seek is not mere support, but partnership”.

On Wednesday, he acknowledged that the French G7 Presidency had given importance to this topic. Speaking for the de-

veloping countries, he said, “The reality today is when it comes to growth, the question should not be about GDP or trade numbers. The real question is: Growth for whom, with whom and in what direction?”

He said India’s experience demonstrated that shared development could help transform aspirations into reality, and the country’s growth story was one of inclusion, scale and democratic empowerment.

“It is inspired by ‘Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas, Sabka Prayas’ (Together with all, development for all, trust of all, efforts by all). And, it has been reflected on countless occasions such as India’s G20 Presidency, the launch of the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) and more.”

“Like the vision of IMEC, can we work on connectivity projects with countries in Africa, Latin America and the Pacific Islands? By combining G7 capital, India’s talent and the ownership of Global South countries, we may also consider establishing an International Mobilisation Partnership for Accelerating Connectivity and Trade (IMPACT),” Modi said as he put forward a new proposal.

Reflecting on the situation in the developed countries, he said, “Today, many societies are becoming ageing societies while India and other countries of the Global South have abundance of young talent, entrepreneurship and skills. To harness this natural complementarity calls for the creation of a Global Skills Partnership, where we can work together on skill mapping and promote trusted skilled mobility.”

QS rankings

year, too, it had dropped 11 ranks.

Globally, Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT) topped the list for the 15th year, followed by Stanford University, Imperial College, University of Oxford and Harvard University.

The Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) continue to dominate the country’s top 10 list. Besides IIT-Delhi and IIT-Bombay, IIT-Madras (ranked 170, up from 180 last year) is the only other Indian institution in the top 200 globally. The others in the top 10 nationally are IIT-Kharagpur (205), IIT-Kanpur (221), Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore (221), University of Delhi (322), IIT-Roorkee (335) and IIT-Guwahati (349). Among these, IISc and IIT-Guwahati have dropped in the rankings as compared to last year.

In fact, IISc has seen its rank slip consistently over the past few years — from 155 in 2023, when it was the top ranked Indian institution, to 219 last year

and 221 this year. While it has a high score of 99.9 on the citations per faculty indicator, it does not fare as well on employer reputation (48.8), and employment outcomes (22.6), which are the metrics where IIT-Delhi and IIT-Bombay outperform the premier research institute.

Apart from these, Shoolini University of Biotechnology and Management Sciences, a private institution in Himachal Pradesh, has also made it to India’s top 10 list with a rank of 452, up from 503 last year.

In a statement to *The Indian Express*, Ben Sowter, QS Senior Vice President, explained the performance by metrics. “IIT-D rose to 39th in the world in employer reputation, and to 60th in the citations per faculty indicators. Additionally, it rose 60 places to rank 280th in employment outcomes. Despite dropping 15 places in academic reputation, it still scores highly in the area, ranking 157th. In the past five years, IIT-D has risen 67 places, with this year’s ranking in citations its best ever — just three years ago, in 2024, it

ranked 182nd in this indicator. These two areas are key to IIT-D achieving such an outstanding rank in 2027,” he said.

Explaining the reasons for IIT-Bombay’s drop in rankings, Sowter said: “Like IIT-D, IIT-Bombay performs exceptionally well in the employer reputation indicator, rising to 32nd in the world. It also rose to 176th in employment outcomes, and, despite dropping, it ranked 126th — and top in India — in the academic reputation indicator. However, a 25-place fall to 161 in citations per faculty has impacted its ranking this year, as do low scores across the global engagement lens (international faculty, international students and international research network). In this area, global peers are gaining momentum while institutions across India are improving at a comparatively slower pace.” The latest edition of rankings features 52 Indian universities, down from 54 last year. For the number of institutions on the list overall, India ranked fifth (52) after the US (184), UK (93), China (85) and Germany (60).

Telegram

before the High Court, Mehta sought time until Thursday to file a response and bring additional material on record. “There is a host of material which I would like the court to see,” he said.

Justice Karia inquired if “complete” blocking of the application was “proportionate”.

Responding in the affirmative, Mehta said, “I will have to show individual users (on the platform)... Several things were there... They were repeatedly told that ‘issues are arising repeatedly, please correct your system’, which they failed to do. That’s what I want to bring on record.” Senior Advocate Dhruv Mehta, appearing for Telegram, said the interim blocking order had not followed the procedure prescribed under the law, and that it suffered from “the vice of non-application of mind”. He said if the interim order itself was faulty, “the final order” would “suffer the same consequences”.

DELHI SLUM AND JJ CLUSTER REHAB POLICY 2026 EXPECTED TO REDUCE RESISTANCE TO SHIFTING TO NEW SITES

Rehabilitation for most slum dwellers, in-situ relocation focus of new policy

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, June 17

NEARLY ALL slum dwellers in the Capital eligible for rehabilitation and priority to relocating them close to the existing slum clusters — these are the highlights of the Delhi Slum and JJ Cluster Rehabilitation and Relocation Policy, 2026, which is set to be notified.

A day after Union Home Minister Amit Shah chaired a key meeting and said that the new policy, which replaces Delhi Slum Rehabilitation and Relocation Policy 2015, is ready, Delhi Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood on Wednesday told *The Indian Express* that the government has extended the cut-off date for slum dwellers eligible for rehabilitation by 10 years, virtually making most slum dwellers in the national capital eligible to get a pucca house. Now, all slum dwellers who live in slums, which existed as on January 1, 2025, will be eligible for rehabili-

tation under the new policy.

The government said the policy will benefit four lakh families, or almost 20 lakh people.

“We are also working on a new provision under which even family members living on the first or second floor of the slum unit will be eligible for rehabilitation by giving an additional charge,” Sood said.

According to officials, the new policy is expected to make the relocation process smoother. “Earlier, we used to see that half the families in a slum were eligible, while the other half were not, which used to lead to resistance and court cases. The new policy will make everyone eligible, so people will cooperate more,” an official said. Tenders will be issued for slum parcels in Mayur Vihar in East Delhi, Seelampur in North-east, Sultanpuri in Northwest, Lajpat Nagar in Southeast and Pitampura in Central North districts, as per Shah’s directions to issue tender for rehabilitation of

In a nutshell



ACROSS DELHI
675
Notified Slums

376 SLUMS located on land owned by Central government agencies such as Railways, L&DO and DDA and rehabilitation is

overseen by DDA; remaining **299 slums** are on Delhi government land, fall under the jurisdiction of DUSIB.

ELIGIBLE BENEFICIARIES receive a 25 sqm dwelling unit by paying ₹1.12 lakh–₹1.41 lakh, along with ₹30,000 towards five years of maintenance.

Rehabilitation currently governed by the Delhi Slum & JJ Rehabilitation and Relocation Policy, 2015

5 slum clusters under public-private partnership (PPP) mode. “Extending the rehabilitation eligibility cut till 2025 is a revolutionary move that will give all slum dwellers in Delhi a pucca house, so that every GenZ in all slums of Delhi can think of a better future. We have also stuck to our promise of Jaha Jhuggi Wahan Makan,” Sood said. Similar to the current policy, he added, slum dwellers will have to pay a sum ranging between

Rs 1.12 lakh to Rs 1.41 lakh to get a house. *The Indian Express* had reported in March that the Delhi government is working on a new slum policy which will extend the eligibility cut-off date from the present January 1, 2015 to January 1, 2025.

Progress on relocation

Slum rehabilitation in the national capital is currently governed by the Delhi government’s Delhi Slum and Jhuggi

Jhopri Rehabilitation and Relocation Policy, 2015, which was brought in by the previous AAP government and subsequently also adopted by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) for slums on central government lands. The rehabilitation process, however, has progressed at an excruciatingly slow pace over the past decade, with only two in-situ projects — Ashok Vihar and Kalkaji, together providing around 4,700 flats — completed so far, both by DDA.

Under the public-private partnership (PPP) model, which the government says it will use, private developers come in to construct housing to rehabilitateslum dwellers on part of the slum land while the remaining land is commercially developed. The underlying rationale is that the developer recovers the cost of building units for slum dwellers by making profits from the ‘free sale’ component. The model was expected to work well since slums are typically located on high-value land in cen-

tral city areas.

However, DDA has struggled to attract private developers, who cite small land parcels, difficult locations near drains and railway tracks, and frequent litigation. The only ongoing PPP redevelopment project is Kathputli Colony in Shadipur. Conceived in 2008 and launched in 2018, the project has faced repeated delays. DDA had said developer Raheja would hand over 2,800 EWS flats by mid-2026, but the target has not been met. Insolvency proceedings against the company were initiated by the NCLT last October.

In 2022, DDA floated proposals or formal bidding documents for six projects covering around 10,300 households and was processing four more projects covering 15,000 households. However, officials said the proposals were eventually shelved due to poor developer response. Apart from Kathputli Colony, no PPP-based slum rehabilitation project is currently underway in Delhi.

• FEWER FARM FIRES SINCE 2022 BUT A SHIFT IN BURNING BEHAVIOUR NEEDS TO BE ACCOUNTED FOR, UNDERLINES CEEW STUDY

‘Partial burning’ continues to be key hurdle in tackling farm fire pollution: Study

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, June 17

FARMERS USING crop residue management machines (CRM) but still setting residual stubble on fire due to concerns such as pest attacks, cost and lack of confidence in alternative methods, also referred as “partial burning”: this behaviour has emerged as a key challenge in tackling pollution due to stubble burning, a latest study has underlined.

Titled ‘Behaviour Change Approaches to Tackle Stubble Burning at Scale: Reimagining Crop Residue Management’, a Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW) study

made available on Tuesday is based on a survey of 102 farmers across Punjab from Sangrur, Ludhiana and Amritsar, focus group discussions with 36 farmers in Amritsar and Kapurthala, and consultations with 15 agriculture officials.

As per the CEEW, a non-profit, crop residue (stubble) burning in Northwest India remains one of the most visible contributors to the region’s severe seasonal air pollution, accounting for up to 30–35% of Delhi’s PM2.5 pollution during the October–November peak season.

According to the latest study, 63% of surveyed farmers reported moving away from com-

plete burning. However, 31% or 1 in 3 continued to partially burn their fields, while 6% still engaged in complete burning, indicating that adoption of crop residue management alternatives remains uneven despite progress. Among farmers who continue to burn residue either partially or completely, 67% cited pest attack prevention as a key reason. However, 57% of them said they had never personally witnessed increased pest attacks, suggesting that peer narratives and hearsay continue to influence field-level decisions.

According to the study, reported farm-fire incidents have declined since 2022, but it has



Stubble burning is a key contributor to pollution in peak season. FILE

cautioned that fire counts need to be read alongside a shift in burning behaviour, timing of fires, satellite-detection limitations and actual adoption of alternatives on the ground.

Referring to a 2025 study by

the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), the report noted that stubble burning is increasingly occurring at different times of the day, potentially affecting satellite-based monitoring of farm fires. Lower reported

fire counts alone may not fully capture whether farmers have shifted to sustained no-burn practices.

The Punjab government’s Unnat Kisan app, meant to support machinery rentals, also had low visibility among surveyed farmers. CEEW found that 86% of surveyed farmers had never heard of the app, indicating a gap in promoting digital public infrastructure that is directly linked to CRM adoption.

Training has been another weak link. The study found that 78% of surveyed farmers were unaware of CRM training schedules.

Among those who attended training, 73% described them as

largely lecture-based, with limited practical demonstrations.

The study has recommended that Punjab build on existing IEC — Information, Education, and Communication — activities but shift towards a dedicated ‘Behaviour Change Communication’ strategy under the CRM scheme. This would mean treating farmers not as a single category, but as distinct groups — those who have never used CRM machinery, those who have just started using it, those who use it regularly, those who stopped after negative experiences, and partial burners who are already close to full adoption.

For partial burners, the study

has recommended targeted technical reassurance, field demonstrations and peer testimonials to address fears around pest attacks, machine reliability and maintenance costs.

The report has also called for district-specific communication. In low-burn villages, with a low frequency of such incidents, the focus should be on completing the shift to no-burn practices, it said. In medium-burn villages, communication should target farmers who have adopted machinery but continue partial burning. In high-burn or partial-burning districts, messaging should directly address local fears such as pest attacks, and operational costs.



At a meeting with Telegram, govt had flagged limited search feature, missing ‘proactive’ steps

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, June 17

ONE OF the key grievances the government has had with messaging platform Telegram is its limited search feature. While, according to the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), Telegram has been

telling the government for the last four years that it has been “working on it”, the platform has opined that “the outright blocking or banning of particular keywords or phrases does not appear to be an appropriate solution”, for content moderation on the platform.

According to the platform, by not being a “content-push platform”, its architecture “inherently limits the discoverability”.

Preceding the June 16 temporary blocking order against Telegram, the government had flagged in a June 3 meeting to the platform that it had failed to upgrade its restricted search feature. As an example, the government cited: the platform did not catch operating channels even if a simple search

with ‘NEET leaked paper’ was conducted.

“It was informed by representatives from MeitY that for the last four years, Telegram has been stating that their search feature is limited and that Telegram is working on it... the Government can take a strict measure against the platform, since Telegram has consistently failed to proactively take measures to control the misuse of the platform,” the minutes from the June 3 meeting notes.

In an email to MeitY on June 5, the platform further explained that “search signals, keywords and other indicators form part of the overall moderation framework and are continuously used to identify and take action against unlawful content, including content relating to examination fraud...”

It also explained that “the outright blocking or banning of particular keywords or phrases does not appear to be an appropriate solution, as such terms may also be used in legitimate con-

texts including by students, educational stakeholders... and news reporting relating to the issue.”

The meeting, convened by MeitY after summoning Telegram representatives, was held to discuss the “scale and nature of the fraud network identified on Telegram with respect to the recent NEET (UG) 2026 examination cycle”. During this meeting, the government had also suggested IMEI-level blocking. However, in the June 5 email, Telegram clarified that it “does not utilise the suggested IMEI-based identifier as part of its enforcement architecture”.

According to the minutes, NTA flagged that it “regularly informed and gave lists to Telegram about the operating channels,” which Telegram said it acted on. The government also flagged the lack of proactive measures “when the issue was at the peak”. However, Telegram said that it has implemented “extensive proactive and reactive moderation measures...”



EU to sign Free Trade Agreement with India by end of 2026, says Ursula at G7

European leaders meet Modi at G7, Merz invites PM to Germany

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 17

EUROPEAN COMMISSION'S President Ursula von der Leyen said on Wednesday that the EU will sign the Free Trade Agreement with India by the end of the year.

She made this comment after meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the sidelines of the G7 Summit.

In another development, German Chancellor Friedrich Merz invited Modi to visit Germany later this year.

European Union's von der Leyen posted on X, "Dear @narendramodi, it is a pleasure to meet again so soon. Since we have concluded the mother of all trade deals, we have been moving fast to deliver on our commitments. We will sign the Free Trade Agreement by the end of the year. And accelerate work on an investment agreement."

"We will also step up security & defence cooperation," she said, adding that EU and India will join forces for better connectivity by advancing IMEC, the India-Middle East-Europe Corridor.



PM Narendra Modi meets European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen and European Council President Antonio Costa on the sidelines of the G7 Summit, in Evian-les-Bains, France. PTI

According to the Ministry of External Affairs, PM Modi on Wednesday held a bilateral meeting with the President of the European Council António Costa and President of the European Commission Ursula von der Leyen, on the sidelines of the G7 Summit in Evian and recalling the landmark 16th India-EU Summit held in India in January 2026. The leaders welcomed the remarkable progress made in India-European Union relations since then.

"The leaders emphasized the recent conclusion of negotiations for the India-EU Free Trade Agreement as a historic achievement and stressed its expeditious signing and implementation, which would unlock huge opportunities for trade and investment and contribute towards diversification of supply chains, particularly in the current turbulent geopolitical context," it said, referring to the wars in West Asia and Ukraine.

"As the world's two largest democracies, with open market economies and pluralistic societies, India and the EU share a relationship based on trust, shared values and a common vision for the future. The leaders discussed the progress on the Joint India-EU Comprehensive Strategic Agenda endorsed in January 2026 and shared the sentiment that it would further reinforce India-EU strategic partnership and deliver mutually beneficial and transformative outcomes," it said.

Exchanging views on regional and global issues of mutual interest, it said that "the leaders welcomed the developments in West Asia. They reiterated their shared commitment to shaping a resilient multipolar global order that contributes to peace and stability, prosperity and sustainable development."

On the meeting with German Chancellor Friedrich Merz on the sidelines of the G7 Summit, the MEA said that the leaders reviewed the progress in bilateral engagements and expressed satisfaction at the renewed momentum in the India-Germany Strategic Partnership, with the successful visit of the Chancellor to India and the conclusion of the India-EU FTA negotiations earlier this year.

Chancellor Merz invited Prime Minister Modi for the 8th India-Germany Inter-Governmental Consultations (IGC), scheduled to be held later this year in Germany.

India will always be on the side of peace, Modi tells Zelenskyy

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, June 17

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi met Ukraine's President Volodymyr Zelenskyy on Wednesday and reiterated that India will "always be on the side of peace, placing the values of humanity over everything else". The two sides discussed trade and industrial projects, which is a significant upgrade in conversation since the war between Russia and Ukraine began almost four-and-a-half years ago.

After meeting him on the sidelines of the G7 Summit in Evian, PM Modi posted on X: "Met President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in Evian. In recent times, India and Ukraine have been engaging extensively. This has been reflected in different areas of our cooperation. Our talks today were about reviewing different aspects of our cooperation."

"We both agree that trade ties need to be restored to what they were in the pre-war time. Also reiterated that India will always be on the side of peace, placing the values of humanity over everything else," he said, tagging Zelenskyy.

The Ukrainian President said, "I met with Prime Minister



PM Narendra Modi meets Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy in France. PTI

of India @narendramodi. Our countries have great potential for cooperation, and we are already implementing joint projects. Today, we discussed how to give them even more substance and expand cooperation across various sectors."

"Importantly, the Prime Minister is interested in developing mutually beneficial relations with Ukraine and sees that this partnership can make our people stronger. There are good industrial and other projects that we can implement together. We agreed that our teams would work through all the details," Zelenskyy said.

E. EXPLAINED

Efforts to engage with Kyiv, Moscow

DELHI AND Kyiv have been discussing a visit by the Ukrainian President for the last six months now. A Zelenskyy visit would reinforce Delhi's effort to stay engaged with both sides of the Russia-Ukraine war. The timing and scope of the proposed visit will depend on multiple factors, including how Trump's peace plan unfolds and developments on the battlefield.

India has stayed in touch with both Russian President Vladimir Putin and Ukrainian President Zelenskyy since the war began in February 2022. Modi has spoken to Zelenskyy by phone at least eight times, and the two leaders have met on at least four occasions.

Their last conversation was on August 30, when Modi reached Tianjin, China, for the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit and was to meet Putin on the sidelines.

The 100-day vigil: How a custodial death case ended in a state-ordered cremation

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, June 17

FOR MORE than 100 days, the body of Akash Delison lay inside the mortuary of a government hospital in southern Tamil Nadu, preserved as evidence of a death his family said the police had caused — and as the centrepiece of their demand for accountability. On Wednesday, that vigil ended without the resolution they had sought.

Delison's family had refused to accept the 26-year-old Dalit man's body from the Government Rajaji Hospital in Madurai, alleging that he had been tortured to death in police custody. On Wednesday, government officials, under heavy police protection, removed his body from the hospital and transported it to the Thathaneri crematorium, a day after the Madras HC ruled

that the body could not remain indefinitely in the mortuary.

His parents, sister and uncle were permitted to accompany the remains and pay their final respects. But the cremation itself was conducted by the authorities, acting on an order issued a day earlier by the Madurai Bench of the Madras HC.

Outside the hospital, relatives and supporters protested the government's decision, asking for more time to appeal. Fourteen people were taken into custody as they attempted to prevent officials from removing the body. Family members alleged they had been threatened with detention.

The confrontation marked the final, painful stage of a case that began with an arrest on March 6 and developed into one of the most disturbing allegations of custodial torture in

Tamil Nadu in recent years.

The allegations

Delison, a resident of Krishnarajapuram in Manamadurai and a member of the SC Pallar community, was detained along with another man in connection with an attempted-murder case. The two were accused of attacking P Jayakumar and R Azhagar with sharp weapons.

The police said Delison sustained a serious leg injury while attempting to escape. His family said the explanation concealed a brutal interrogation.

Delison had given a statement to a judicial magistrate describing what he said had happened in police custody before he died on March 8. According to the declaration, officers blindfolded him, positioned stones beneath his ankle and knee, covered his leg with a wet sack



Family members mourn during the last rites of Akash Delison, in Madurai on Wednesday. ANI

and struck it with an iron rod. "Immediately upon being hit, the bone broke and protruded out, and there was bleeding," he said in the statement.

The alleged use of a wet sack was particularly chilling to lawyers and rights advocates with

activists claiming that it is used to reduce obvious external marks even as blows cause fractures, internal bleeding and extensive damage to muscles, nerves and blood vessels.

Delison's family refused to receive the body after the post-

mortem examination, demanding the arrest of all 16 police personnel they believed were connected to the episode.

Six officers were eventually suspended and the investigation was transferred to the Crime Branch-Criminal Investigation Department, or CB-CID.

The aftermath

But the suspensions did not satisfy the family. Its refusal to bury or cremate Delison transformed the hospital mortuary into a prolonged site of protest. Forensic findings added to the questions surrounding the police account. The post-mortem documented more than two dozen injuries, including fractures of the tibia and fibula, extensive muscle and nerve damage, wounds on the elbows and knees, and multiple abrasions. A large internal contusion,

measuring roughly 45 centimetres by 12 centimetres, was recorded around the injured leg. Forensic experts also allegedly identified apparent discrepancies between the initial medical records and the final autopsy, including differences concerning the possible role of a fat embolism in Delison's death.

The pattern and severity of the injuries prompted questions over whether they could reasonably have resulted from a fall. Concerns were also raised over whether all NHRC protocols governing custodial deaths had been followed.

The state continued to deny that Delison had been tortured. Its lawyers told the HC that he had never been taken to Manamadurai police station and that his injuries occurred during his attempt to escape. The government said the criminal case had

nevertheless been altered to include murder and provisions of the SC/ST Act. The family was given Rs 6 lakh in compensation.

On Tuesday, Justice L Victoria Gowri ruled that the body could not remain indefinitely in the mortuary. A decent burial or cremation, the judge said, was an extension of human dignity.

The case has carried political consequences beyond Manamadurai. Custodial deaths and allegations of police excess became one of the recurring stains on the former DMK government, damaging its claims of socially just and humane governance. They were among the issues that opposition parties used to portray the administration as unaccountable before its electoral defeat. For Delison's family, however, the political reckoning remains secondary to an unanswered demand.

The Editorial Page

THURSDAY, JUNE 18, 2026

For lasting peace, US & Iran have to look beyond their philosophies of negotiation



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

THE LONG-DRAWN-OUT impasse between Washington and Tehran, now finally (we hope!) ended, is frequently dissected through the lenses of realpolitik, regional rivalries, and nuclear politics. Analysts pointing to the technical mechanics of uranium enrichment, the labyrinth of secondary economic sanctions, or the shifting geopolitics of the Middle East are certainly not wrong. These structural disputes formed the visible bedrock of the stalemate. Yet, beneath the policy papers, the diplomats scurrying about and the intelligence briefings, lies a deeper, more insidious barrier to peace: A total, systemic collision of negotiating philosophies. Diplomacy has failed so far not just because the two sides disagree on the terms, but because they fundamentally disagree on what it means to negotiate.

This conceptual chasm is vividly illuminated by a fascinating, almost cinematic juxtaposition of two texts written by central protagonists of the Iran-US standoff: Donald Trump's *The Art of the Deal* (1987) and Abbas Araghchi's *The Power of Negotiation* (2014). Araghchi, a career diplomat who served as Iran's deputy foreign minister and chief nuclear negotiator during the landmark JCPOA talks, is now the foreign minister. He offers an intellectual framework that stands in diametrical opposition to the American populist-transactional model popularised by Trump. When these two texts are placed side by side, they expose an incom-

patibility of diplomatic DNA that explains why years of high-stakes engagement so often ended in mutual incomprehension.

The first major fault line runs between Trump's raw transactionalism and Araghchi's deeply ingrained institutionalism. In *The Art of the Deal*, negotiation is framed as a zero-sum game driven by personality, leverage, and hyperbole. For Trump, the individual negotiator is a maverick star, and established institutional frameworks — whether they are government departments, multilateral treaties, or international bodies — are treated not as assets but as irritating obstacles designed to stall a “great deal”. The goal is a highly visible, unambiguous triumph that can be summarised on a balance sheet, a photo-op or a headline.

Araghchi, who holds a PhD in political thought, presents a radically different worldview. In *The Power of Negotiation*, diplomacy is treated as a systematic, scholarly discipline rooted in what he calls “smart power” — the precise blend of hard national capabilities and soft diplomatic skill. For Araghchi, the individual negotiator is never a lone wolf or a dealmaker looking for a personal win. He is the solemn representative of a state with millennia of civilisational history. This approach operates within strict, immutable principles of statecraft and strategic autonomy. Where the American model values flexibility and personal instinct, the Iranian model demands institutional discipline and adherence to long-term national grand strategy.

This institutional divide manifests practically in the clash between the mechanics of the bazaar and the psychology of Trump's “Big Play”. Araghchi explicitly references the “bazaar-style” or “market-style” of negotiation — a time-honoured method defined by infinite patience, deliberate ambiguity, and incremental, exhausting haggling. In this framework, time

This conceptual chasm is vividly illuminated by a fascinating, almost cinematic juxtaposition of two texts: Donald Trump's ‘The Art of the Deal’ (1987) and Abbas Araghchi's ‘The Power of Negotiation’ (2014)

is not an enemy to be beaten, but a potential ally to be weaponised. The bazaar mentality relies on running down the clock, using the cultural art of *taarof* (a complex system of ritualised politeness and deference) to mask unyielding positions and test the opponent's resolve. To the Iranian diplomat, if you wait long enough, the Western opponent's domestic electoral urgency and impatience will eventually become your leverage.

Conversely, Trump's philosophy is built entirely on momentum, disruption, and the adrenaline of the “closer”. His strategy relies on “the squeeze” — making maximalist demands, applying maximum pressure, escalating tensions, and threatening total breakdown to force a quick, high-stakes breakthrough. Where Araghchi sees a marathon designed to outlast the adversary, Trump sees a sprint toward a definitive signature.

This collision creates a devastating feedback loop of misinterpretation. When Araghchi and the Iranian diplomatic apparatus deploy their classic bazaar-style delay tactics, Washington reads it as a total lack of “seriousness” or a sign of bad faith. When Trump or subsequent American administrations apply “maximum pressure” or unilaterally rip up existing frameworks to demand a better bargain, Tehran does not see a shrewd opening gambit; they view it as an “uncivilised”, lawless departure from the sacred rules of international engagement.

Ultimately, the issue is that these two worldviews are chasing entirely different destinations. The transactional American model seeks a definitive surrender or a brand-new “grand bargain” that mirrors a corporate business acquisition — a clean break from the past sealed by a photographic handshake. The Iranian model, shaped by Araghchi's philosophy, seeks something far more abstract: A managed, permanent state of bal-

anced leverage that preserves national dignity and strategic autonomy through an incredibly dense, complex web of technical clauses. One side wants a final contract; the other wants a perpetual process.

Of course, this philosophical clash does not exist in a vacuum. Other formidable factors contribute heavily to the perpetual deadlock. The intense pressure of domestic politics in both nations severely limits the room for compromise. In Washington, any concession to Tehran is routinely vilified by congressional hawks as weakness, while in Tehran, the ultimate authority rests with a clerical establishment and parliamentary hawks deeply suspicious of Western intentions, who view compromise as an existential threat to the revolutionary state's identity. Furthermore, regional alignments — specifically the security anxieties of Israel and the Gulf states — ensure that any bilateral progress between the US and Iran triggers immediate counter-pressures that can derail negotiations.

Yet, even if these political and regional hurdles have now been cleared, the structural mismatch of negotiating styles will remain an existential threat to any dialogue, including the “final negotiation” to come. The tragedy of US-Iran diplomacy is that both sides are reading from entirely different scripts. Until Washington understands that it cannot treat a civilisational state like a distressed real-estate asset to be squeezed into submission, and until Tehran realises that its infinite bazaar-style patience will continually be misread as defiance by an impatient American political system, the “art of the deal” and the “power of negotiation” will continue to produce nothing but the anatomy of a stalemate.

The writer is a fourth-term Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha) for Thiruvananthapuram and chairman of the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs

To recover lost ground, ISI must look to IITs, IIMs



R A MASHELKAR AND ADIL ZAINULBHAH

P C MAHALANOBIS started the Indian Statistical Institute (ISI) in Kolkata in 1931 with a simple conviction: That rigorous statistical thinking could make India a better-governed country. Within a generation, ISI was informing the Five Year Plans, building the National Sample Survey from scratch, and sending graduates to institutions around the world. It was, for a time, genuinely world-class. That is no longer obviously true. And the reasons are worth stating plainly.

We live in a moment when AI and machine learning are remaking every industry, every government function, every research discipline. The foundations of all of it, probability, inference, uncertainty, modelling, are what ISI was built to teach. The institution should be at the centre of this moment. Instead, it is watching from the sidelines. Not because of any shortage of talent inside its walls. But because its governance has made it almost impossible to change.

We say this as members of the 4th Review Committee, which submitted its findings in 2021. What we found was not a failing institution. We found dedicated researchers, proud alumni, and genuinely excellent students. What we also found was a structure that had quietly calcified over decades. The Governing Council, which should be a lean body setting strategic direction, had grown to 33 members, 17 of whom are effectively insiders. Division heads are chosen by internal elections, which tend to reward popularity over academic leadership. The General Body, with over 1,000 members, many of them former staff, holds a veto on any serious reform. Four successive Review Committees going back to 1966 recommended a smaller, more agile council. The council got bigger each time.

The IITs are the obvious comparison, and it is not a flattering one for ISI. IIT Kharagpur was converted into a proper statutory body in 1956, three years before the ISI Act was

even passed. The Institutes of Technology Act of 1961 gave every IIT a compact board, merit-based appointments, and genuine room to grow. The IIMs got similar architecture in 2017. Both systems expanded dramatically in size, quality and global standing. ISI, still running on a society structure from the 1930s, did not.

The Draft ISI Bill, 2026 addresses the core problem. An 11-member Board of Governance with balanced internal and external representation replaces the current unwieldy council. ISI becomes a body corporate, which removes the procedural veto that has blocked change for 50 years. The regional centres in Delhi, Bengaluru, Chennai and Tezpur get real administrative and financial autonomy, long overdue. And the institute's mandate formally expands to include AI and allied disciplines. That last point matters: ISI should not need legislative permission to teach AI, but given where it has been stuck, the explicit mandate helps.

One thing the Bill alone cannot fix is scale. ISI admits around 550 to 600 students a year. IITs admit close to 2,500. For an institution that wants to be genuinely competitive by its centenary in 2031, that gap has to close. India needs more people trained to think carefully about data, not fewer. The talent pool is there. The demand from industry and government is real. What has been missing is the institutional capacity to respond.

During the original Lok Sabha debate on the ISI Bill in December 1959, several members warned about exactly the governance problems we see today. They were right, and it took 66 years to respond legislatively.

The Bill is a good start. Now it needs to be implemented with the same seriousness with which it was drafted.

Mashelkar is former director-general of CSIR. He chaired the 4th ISI Review Committee. Zainulbhai is former chairman of the Capacity Building Commission and former chairman of McKinsey India. He served on the 4th ISI Review Committee

ISI admits around 550 to 600 students a year. IITs admit close to 2,500. For an institution that wants to be genuinely competitive by its centenary in 2031, that gap has to close

Exam failures run deeper than Telegram

THE GOVERNMENT'S decision to temporarily block Telegram ahead of the re-conducted National Eligibility Cum Entrance Test (NEET) to medical institutions is an ill-thought-out move. Investigators probing the May 3 exam fiasco believe that the messaging app was used to circulate leaked papers. The National Testing Agency (NTA) — which conducts NEET and other important examinations — has argued that fraudsters were exploiting the platform to spread misinformation. Acting on its recommendation, the government has directed Telegram to disable message-editing features allegedly used to create fake evidence of paper leaks. The NTA's argument may well be valid. Identifying where the illicit papers appeared is important. But the more crucial question is how this subterfuge escaped scrutiny in the first place. As investigations into last month's leak have indicated, the roots of the illegal activity lie in the chain of custody which governs the setting, printing, transportation and distribution of the NEET papers. Proscribing one platform will not eliminate these underlying vulnerabilities.

In the aftermath of last month's exam cancellation, the government has taken some meaningful steps. It has strengthened coordination between the NTA, cybercrime units, and law enforcement agencies. Investigative agencies have widened inquiries into the paper mafia, and law enforcers have clamped down on networks allegedly involved in circulating leaked materials. These targeted actions need to be expanded and given institutional heft. In contrast, the ban on Telegram is a blunt measure that could inconvenience a large section of people. With an estimated 150 million users, the platform is second only to Meta's WhatsApp in reach. The stringent measures against the messaging app, therefore, speak of executive overreach and go against the principles of proportionality.

In the past two decades, repeated instances of malpractice have raised questions over the examination system's integrity. Last month's failure was the second controversy over the medical entrance test in two years. The Radhakrishnan Committee, appointed by the government on the SC's nudge — after the 2024 examinations were roiled by allegations of irregularities — recommended strengthening the NTA's accountability mechanism. The agency's use of private vendors has drawn criticism from parliamentary panels. Experts are unanimous about the importance of sustained vigilance in making the system foolproof. As the Radhakrishnan Committee underlined, safeguarding the sanctity of examinations should be a continuous process. The government's imperative, in other words, should not just be to secure the NEET examination on June 21, but all entrance and job application tests. By picking on Telegram, it appears to be lapsing into a familiar failing — treating the NEET cancellation as an isolated case, and not a symptom of a broken system.

On cough syrups, a long overdue prescription

THE CENTRE'S decision to remove cough syrups from Schedule K of the Drugs Rules, 1945 — the list of medicines that can be sold without a prescription — is a belated but necessary acknowledgement of a regulatory failure that has persisted for years and resulted in multiple tragedies. In October 2025, over 20 children died across Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan after consuming locally procured cough syrups. Between December 2019 and January 2020, there were similar casualties in Jammu. These domestic disasters came on top of a scarred international record: India-made cough syrups have been tied to the deaths of more than 140 children in Africa and Central Asia since 2022.

Cough syrups occupy an anomalous position in India's drug regulation framework. While recognised as medicines, many formulations — crucially those under Entry number 13 of Schedule K — benefitted from exemptions that enabled their sale through channels subject to weaker oversight than licensed pharmacies. This has fostered a culture of self-medication, poor prescription discipline and fragmented accountability across the supply chain. Particularly affected are vulnerable communities, especially in villages with a population of less than 1,000, where their sale was permitted — in MP, for instance, it was found that the cough syrup in question, Coldrif, contained diethylene glycol far in excess of permissible limits. The change in law translates to a shift in access. All syrup-based medicines, including cough syrups containing opioids like codeine, can no longer be purchased over the counter.

Yet the prescription mandate, on its own, is unlikely to be sufficient. Drug regulation in India suffers from a Centre-state coordination deficit, and investigations after tragedies have repeatedly pointed to loopholes in quality control and inspection, raising uncomfortable questions about the capacity of regulators to monitor a rapidly expanding pharma sector. Concerns also remain about rural India, where limited access to healthcare facilities risks pushing people toward unlicensed vendors. The new rule must, therefore, be accompanied by rigorous enforcement, greater transparency in reporting adverse events, and investment in rural healthcare. The country must focus on a regulatory culture that prioritises patient safety over crisis management.

Measuring the economy, from the ground up



SACHIN CHATURVEDI

THE RECENT governing council meeting of NITI Aayog was notable as it signalled a decisive shift in how India intends to think about economic growth itself. The Prime Minister's call for district-level GDP estimates that intend to measure the economic performance of each of the country's more than 700 districts is the formal institutionalisation of an idea whose time has arrived.

For most of the post-Independence period, the architecture of economic measurement was built upward. National aggregates were primary; states disaggregated them; districts and villages were residual. The assumption was that growth percolates. We have learnt that it does not. As per NITI Aayog's SDG India Index, the top 100 districts by GSDP contribute roughly 40 per cent of India's output; the bottom 400 contribute under 15 per cent. The Aspirational Districts Programme, launched in 2018, targeting 112 lagging districts, improved outcomes in several of them, but operated without a robust economic baseline.

What gets measured gets tracked in terms of economic growth; district-level GDP changes the cumulative state-level plans. K V Raju's work in the context of Uttar Pradesh is such an attempt; I have had the occasion to examine this deficit from close quarters. During my tenure as vice chairman of the Madhya Pradesh State Policy and Planning Commission, the fragility of sub-national data became apparent. How many of the 4,677 factories registered in Madhya Pradesh actually operated after the Covid crisis? The Annual Survey of Industries as of 2021, covering a sample of only 60 units, could not answer it. District-level estimates across India are still largely derived from state-level coefficients projected downward; this is a methodological inheritance that has undermined policy precision for decades.

The significance of district-level GDP goes well beyond correcting a measurement gap. Districts are where industries open and close, where credit reaches or fails to reach, where labour migrates. The vision of districts as export hubs, ready for participation in global value chains, cannot be operationalised without knowing what a district actually produces.

The 15th Finance Commission (FC) urged states to channel resources more directly to district administrations; the 16th FC has continued in this vein. Yet resources transferred without a clear picture of local needs often diffuse without traceable impact. District GDP can provide the analytical scaffolding for fiscal devolution.

The informal economy presents the most immediate methodological challenge: Agriculture, petty trade, construction and domestic services remain unorganised and difficult to enumerate. MoSPI has been working on methodological reforms, and state statistical directorates, once adequately staffed, can contribute to a bottom-up data architecture.

There is a larger argument that the NITI Aayog meeting has implicitly made: That the journey to Viksit Bharat by 2047 cannot be charted at 30,000 feet. Growth that bypasses districts is growth that bypasses people. Reversing distress migration and converting India's demographic dividend into productive economic force requires granular, district-level knowledge. GDP is an incomplete measure of welfare, but it is the indispensable starting point. Once districts are on the map, measuring well-being alongside income becomes possible.

The participation of all 28 chief ministers for the first time reflects a maturing of cooperative federalism that localisation demands. States must own the data, build the capacity, and commit to the transparency district GDP will require. Sukhamoy Chakravarty's *Development Planning: The Indian Experience* (1987) makes a central point: That local planning is closely connected to the capabilities of those tasked with carrying it out, and that district-level capacity-building is a precondition. Three things will determine whether our commitment holds.

The first is investment in district-level administrative capacity. Understanding what a district income estimate requires, what data to collect, how to validate it, what sectoral priorities suit the district's resource endowment. Second is institutional coherence. NITI Aayog sets the national framework; state NITI Aayogs and district planning committees are supposed to operationalise it on the ground; but they do not work in tandem with each other. Third is treating districts as the unit of India's international economic engagement. It is in the districts that productive capacity resides for responding to emerging trade opportunities.

Measurement, capacity, coherence, and an outward-looking development imagination: These are the four threads the NITI Aayog meeting has put in play. That is what localisation, at its most meaningful, looks like.

The writer is vice chancellor, Nalanda University. Views are personal



JAYNA KOTHARI

JUNE 2 was a proud and emotional day for women lawyers as we witnessed the appointment of Justice V Mohana, only the second woman from the Bar to be appointed directly to the Supreme Court. The battle for women in India to reach the higher echelons in the legal profession has been anything but easy. For women lawyers to become judges of the Supreme Court of India is a glass ceiling that has not been shattered yet. The Court has appointed nine male judges directly from the Bar. They all had long tenures, with Justice S M Sikri and Justice U U Lalit becoming chief justices, and current appointees Justice PS Narasimha and Justice K V Viswanathan also due to become chief justices. Justice Indu Malhotra, who was the first woman lawyer directly appointed to the Supreme Court in 2018, had a tenure of less than three years, due to which she did not even become part of the Collegium.

Jurisdictions the world over are bringing structural constitutional reforms to ensure gender equality in their highest courts. In 2014, Belgium passed an amendment modifying Article 34(5) of the Special Act of 6 January 1989 concerning its constitutional court. This amendment introduced a gender quota mandating that at least one-third of the 12 judges must belong to each sex. Till the court reached the composition of

All the recent appointments of male judges were made based on such representation. Then why not a quota to ensure 33.3 per cent gender representation?



one-third women judges, it was mandated that after every two male appointees, the third appointment would have to be of a woman. The Belgian constitutional court also has linguistic and professional quotas for judges.

In South Africa, Section 174 (2) of the constitution mandates that the judiciary must reflect the country's racial and gender composition. Currently, six of the South African constitutional court's 11 judges are women, making it one of the first women-majority constitutional courts anywhere in the world, and it has a woman chief justice.

Quotas for representation are not new. Even in our Supreme Court, appointments of judges are made keeping in mind the representation from different high courts. All the recent appointments of male judges were made based on such representation. Then why not a quota to ensure 33.3 per cent gender representation?

Even with the appointment of Justice Mohana, the percentage of women in our Supreme Court is a woeful 5.4 per cent, with only two women judges out of 37. Meanwhile, the proportion of women judges in the most progressive supreme courts is moving towards 50 per cent and ensuring that at least 33.3 per cent are women. 54.5 per cent of the judges of South Africa's constitutional court are women, as are 50 per cent of the

judges in Canada, Belgium, and Germany's top courts. The figure is 44.4 per cent for the US, 42.85 for Australia and 33.33 per cent for France. Meanwhile, Singapore falls below the 33 per cent mark with around 24 per cent of its SC judges being women, and Nepal and the UK fare even worse at roughly 17 per cent each.

Measures have to be taken for equal representation of women in India's Supreme Court. This needs the targeted inclusion of women from the Bar, from minority faiths, and from SC/ST and OBC communities. Ideally, an amendment to Articles 124 and 217 of the Constitution would be required to direct that appointments of judges to the SC and HCs should reflect the gender and caste composition of the country. Till this is done, the SC needs to introduce a stated written policy to have 33.3 per cent women on the Court, which will direct targeted appointments. We can adopt the easy strategy used in Belgium, that after every two appointments of male judges in the Court, the next appointment must be of a woman till we reach 33.3 per cent.

While we take pride in Justice Mohana's appointment, we have to work towards getting an equal number of women judges on the Supreme Court of our country and build a road map to get there.

The writer is a senior advocate, Supreme Court of India, and executive director, Centre for Law & Policy Research

A gender quota to break glass ceiling in judiciary

When red-ant chutney becomes gourmet



NANDINI TANK

PERHAPS THE most revealing aspect of contemporary food politics is not what people eat, but who is eating it. In 2025, viewers across the world watched a contestant on MasterChef Australia prepare a coriander and green ant ice-cream. Food critics praised the creativity. The comment section read: "Shows a versatile cook," "Wish I could have tasted all those amazing elements." Now look at the responses received by eugene_ke_cuisine, a tribal content creator from the Kharia tribe, when he posted a video of demta chutney (red ant chutney) on Instagram: "Disgusting," "I want to puke," "Adivasis (with a disgust emoji)".

The ingredients are similar. The difference lies not in the ant itself but in the social location of those cooking and consuming it.

Earlier this month, the official Instagram handle of Jharkhand Tourism posted about red ant chutney, captioning it "When celebrity chef Gordon Ramsay tasted red ant chutney" — connecting a local indigenous food tradition to a global culinary conversation. It marked an important shift. Food that was once stigmatised is increasingly being recognised as a symbol of regional identity and cultural richness. Yet this recognition itself reveals the problem: When Ramsay tries red ant chutney, it becomes an object of curiosity, framed as adventurous and culturally significant. When indigenous food enters elite culinary spaces, it is rebranded as heritage cuisine or sustainable gastronomy. When it is practised within indigenous communities,

it is treated as evidence of backwardness. For generations, tribal communities across central and eastern India have consumed red ant chutney not merely as food but as part of local ecological knowledge — rich in nutrients, closely connected to forest ecosystems, and emerging through centuries of interaction with local environments. Yet these traditions are dismissed until redis-

When indigenous food enters elite culinary spaces, it is rebranded as heritage cuisine or sustainable gastronomy. When it is practised within indigenous communities, it is treated as evidence of backwardness

covered or endorsed by someone occupying a more privileged social position.

Urban consumers enthusiastically embrace sushi, kimchi, escargot, and imported gourmet ingredients, now marketed as markers of sophistication and cosmopolitanism. When tribal communities showcase their own food traditions, rooted in ecological knowledge, the response is mostly rejection. The issue is not taste. It is power. Certain groups possess the authority to define what is acceptable and desirable. Others are forced to defend their practices against accusations of inferiority. When a tribal dish is mocked online, what is being rejected is not the ingredient but the people associated with it.

This is why Instagram reels by young Adivasi creators matter. Across Jharkhand and the Chota Nagpur region, they are putting out cooking videos to showcase traditional

dishes made from forest produce — wild greens, millets, mushrooms, fish, and red ants. This knowledge rarely appears in textbooks, is ignored by policymakers, and is absent from mainstream media. Yet it survives through oral traditions and everyday cooking. More than recipes, these posts are acts of cultural affirmation — transforming social media into a digital archive of indigenous food cultures, and signalling a growing confidence among tribal youth who refuse to be defined by external perceptions. Every video of demta chutney, silk worms, or mahua is a declaration that tribal cuisines are not relics of the past but living traditions deserving visibility, respect, and pride.

The writer is assistant professor, Department of English and Cultural Studies, CHRIST (Deemed to be University), Bengaluru

G7 LEADERS WELCOME U.S.-IRAN DEAL, CALL FOR IMMEDIATE CEASEFIRE IN LEBANON

Trump on Iran deal: ‘If I don’t like it, we’ll go back to shooting, dropping bombs’

‘I’M THE BOSS’



G7 leaders prior to start of a working session at the summit in Evian-les-Bains, France, on Wednesday, AP

Reuters

Evian (France), Dubai, June 17

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump said on Wednesday his new ceasefire agreement with Iran was not final and he could resume the war if he is unsatisfied, even as Israel launched fresh airstrikes in Lebanon where fighting threatens the wider truce.

“It’s a memorandum of understanding. And if I don’t like it, we’ll go back to shooting at them, dropping bombs on their head,” Trump said at a G7 summit in France of the agreement, reached three days ago.

“If I don’t like it, if they don’t behave, we’ll go right back to dropping bombs right smack in the middle of their head, OK?”

Leaders hailed the agreement at the summit, held in the French town of Evian-les-Bains, an hour’s drive along the shore of Lake Geneva from where the Iran ceasefire memorandum is due to be signed at a ceremony across the Swiss border Friday.

The leaders demanded an immediate ceasefire in Lebanon, where the memorandum calls for a halt to hostilities between Israel and the Iran-backed Hezbollah group have displaced more than a million people.

Fighting there has abated but not ceased since the agreement

Trump thanks Xi and Putin for staying ‘neutral’

Evian: US President Donald Trump on Wednesday described Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin as “neutral” during the war with Iran. “I want to thank China, President Xi, and he stayed neutral,” Trump said, adding: “And I want to thank Vladimir Putin, he was very neutral”. **REUTERS**

was reached on Sunday, and Israel, which was not part of the negotiations, says it retains the right to use force.

Lebanese state media reported fresh Israeli air strikes and artillery fire in several southern towns throughout Wednesday. Lebanese security sources said Hezbollah had also launched two drone attacks on Israeli forces in the south. The group did not publicly claim the attacks. Israel later said five of its soldiers had been injured in two Hezbollah drone attacks in southern Lebanon.

Inside the southern Lebanese city of Nabatieh, below a mediaeval castle seized by Israeli forces, buildings had been blasted to ruins resembling the

Gaza Strip. Khodr Kodeih, a member of the town council, told *Reuters* that some displaced residents had come back to check on their homes in recent days, but that the fresh strikes were again keeping them away.

“The city of Nabatieh emptied out again. We hope a safe environment can be secured so people can return, because the basic necessities of life are still not available,” Kodeih said.

The memorandum of understanding, yet to be made public three days after it was signed by Washington and Tehran, extends a ceasefire announced in April by another 60 days to allow them to negotiate a permanent truce.

The G7 summit gave Trump a chance to present his deal with Iran to allies Britain, Canada, France, Germany, Italy and Japan. They share Washington’s concerns about Iran’s nuclear programme and other issues, but never endorsed his decision to go to war, and worry Tehran has gained leverage by withstanding the superpower onslaught and asserting control over the strait.

“We underline the need for the negotiation ... to address the threats posed by Iran in the region and beyond and ensure that they never obtain a nuclear weapon,” the G7 leaders said.

Reuters

Evian (France), June 17

US PRESIDENT Donald Trump on Wednesday told a roomful of global leaders “I’m the boss”, as he and other G7 leaders acknowledged Ukraine’s improved battlefield fortunes with a unified pledge of support and fresh sanctions against Russia.

Trump’s comment - a tongue-in-cheek admission of an unspoken truth hanging over the June 15-17 summit of the Group of Seven powers - came as he arrived to take his

seat at a session on global economic security, where leaders were due to discuss supply chains for critical minerals and macroeconomic imbalances.

This followed a joint leaders’ statement that could bolster Kyiv’s growing leverage in potential peace talks with Moscow.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy and his allies came to the G7 hoping to impress upon Trump that Ukraine’s fightback is delivering results, and that Russia is in no position to be dictating terms for any peace deal.

The joint statement and comments from leaders suggest Trump has warmed to Zelenskyy’s argument after years of scepticism.

However, any hopes of strongarming Moscow into peace talks still rely on Trump commitments, which can be elusive. It was unclear if bilateral Trump-Zelenskyy talks would take place, and it also remains to be seen if Washington will allow waivers to lapse on sanctions restricting Russian oil exports, now that he has secured a preliminary Iran deal.

● HOT MIC AT THE G7

The leaders of the world’s richest democracies are talking about how to tackle some of the world’s biggest problems this week, but hot mics at the G7 summit revealed that conversations also covered sports, cigarettes and the weather.

Meloni Quits Smoking

● Italian PM Giorgia Meloni’s smoking habits were the subject of a hot mic moment on Tuesday. Asked by German Chancellor Friedrich Merz if she had already had a cigarette that morning, Meloni revealed that she hadn’t smoked “since the first of May.”

● Her turn against tobacco prompted enthusiastic congratulations from leaders of Canada, the UK, Japan and the European Union. Canadian PM Mark Carney had a question for her: “Do you have a patch?” Carney asked, grabbing his own arm.

Trump on Greenland

● In a moment of intrigue, Trump was caught on microphone talking with European Council President António Costa. “You understand?” Trump said before pausing and looking squarely at Costa. “Greenland.” The start and end of the conversation was unclear.

Macron Loses Track of Time

● Trump added some levity after Macron appeared to have left his watch behind when he departed the group’s working lunch. Carney drew attention to it, saying, “He’s



US President Donald Trump, German Chancellor Friedrich Merz, European Council President Antonio Costa and Italian Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni at the G7 Summit in Evian, France. AP

left his watch here. We’ve got his watch.” Trump said, “Give me it if he left, gimme.”

Cage Match

● US President Donald Trump turned attention to the UFC cage match event he hosted at the White House on Sunday. Trump spoke glowingly about Dana White, the CEO of UFC.

● ‘Allez Les Bleus!’

With the World Cup underway in the US, Mexico and Canada,

soccer naturally became a fallback of discussion. As leaders gathered for lunch, French President Emmanuel Macron and others weighed in. Someone shouted “Allez les bleus,” the cheer for the French team. Another leader can be heard talking about the recent Champions League victory by Paris-Saint Germain. At another point in the day, UK PM Keir Starmer refused about Cape Verde’s surprise 0-0 draw against World Cup champion Spain. “Quite remarkable, I have to say,” he said. **AP**

● KEY POINTS FROM DRAFT US-IRAN DEAL

● An immediate and permanent end to the war on all fronts, including in Lebanon.

● Respect each other’s sovereignty and territorial integrity.

● To negotiate and reach a final agreement within a maximum period of 60 days; extendable.

● US lifts the naval blockade and prevents any obstruction against Iran, and restores traffic within 30 days to its full capacity.

● Iran to ensure movement of merchant ships from Persian Gulf to Sea of Oman, and back, is resumed within 30 days.

● The US undertakes to create a comprehensive plan for the rehabilitation and economic development of Iran; \$300 bn financing.

● The US commits to ending all types of sanctions against Iran.

● Iran reiterates that it will never produce nuclear weapons. The fate of enriched material to be addressed in a final agreement.

● Iran will maintain the status quo on its nuclear programme.

● US Treasury Department will issue waivers for exports of Iranian crude oil, petrochemical products.

● The US undertakes that frozen or restricted funds and assets of Iran will be released and made fully available.

● Final agreement will be approved through a binding resolution of the UN Security Council.

REUTERS



US President Donald Trump with OpenAI CEO Sam Altman (left) and Google DeepMind CEO Demis Hassabis at the G7 Summit lunch on AI and Innovation in Evian, France, on Wednesday, Reuters

G7 leaders, top tech bosses discuss AI security and Mythos

Reuters

Evian (France), June 17

FRENCH PRESIDENT Emmanuel Macron said on Wednesday he believed progress would be made in coming weeks on broadening access to leading US AI models, as G7 leaders pledged closer coordination on the risks and opportunities of frontier AI. Macron’s comments came as G7 leaders discussed the creation of a “trusted partners” scheme granting access for non-US nations to advanced US AI models from firms like Anthropic.

Cybersecurity experts are concerned Anthropic’s Mythos, developed to find coding flaws to bolster cyberdefences, could potentially turbo-charge attacks on the very systems it aims to

protect. US President Donald Trump said on Wednesday that negotiations with artificial intelligence company Anthropic are “going fine.” Anthropic is in a dispute with the Trump administration over foreign access to its most advanced AI models, Fable 5 and Mythos 5.

Macron said it was in Washington’s interest to make Mythos more broadly available, as nobody would buy US AI if there were fears it could be shut off at any moment.

Europe is struggling to balance a push for greater tech sovereignty, while also keeping pace with technological advances largely led by US tech firms that dominate cloud computing, semiconductor design and cutting-edge AI research.

STEEL TRADE DIFFERENCES RESOLVED

India-UK FTA to come into force on July 15



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with British counterpart Keir Starmer during the G7 Summit in France. REUTERS

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 17

THE INDIA-UK trade deal is set to come into effect on July 15 after both countries, during last-minute talks in London this week, resolved differences over the terms of steel trade, which had delayed the implementation of the trade deal. The UK had announced fresh steel curbs in March this year, much after India and the UK had concluded the negotiations last year in July, which added a layer of complexity in trade ties.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said that the agreement will significantly boost bilateral trade and investment and will unlock numerous opportunities for Indian farmers, workers and MSMEs.

Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal said that the deal leverages India's manufacturing prowess, service capabilities, and grassroots production directly into one of the world's premier consumer markets.

On the logjam over steel, the Commerce and Industry Ministry said that India and the UK have reached a "consensus" to safeguard steel trade and that India's steel and steel product exports would be protected through a carveout under three categories — country-specific quota (CSQ), residual quota and Authorised Use Scheme (AUS).

"India and the UK have successfully reached a landmark consensus to safeguard and promote bilateral steel trade. Following constructive deliberations regarding the UK's upcoming steel measures effective July 1, 2026, both sides mutually agreed to protect commercial interests, minimise market disruptions, and ensure an overall balanced and stable trading environment for exporters. About 85% of India's exports are out of the steel measures. On the lines under the Steel measures, India's in-

terest has been protected through a mix of CSQ, residual quota and access under AUS," the ministry said in a statement on Wednesday.

This arrangement means that Indian steel shipments would be allowed in three buckets: one where a dedicated quota would be given to India, under which Indian steel products will not be competing with other countries, a second where goods will face competition and a third where certain specialised steel items required by the UK get quicker access.

The resolution over the UK's steel curbs assumes significance as the Indian steel industry has told the government that Indian steel exports would decline despite the free trade agreement (FTA).

Indian officials had said that they would move to restrict UK whiskey exports if Indian interests were hurt due to the curbs. India negotiators were in London for steel related negotiations this week, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal.

Following similar steps announced by the EU and US, the UK said that starting July 1, it would limit tariff-free steel imports by reducing overall quota volumes by 60% for all countries, including those with which it signed an FTA. "Any imports above these levels will then face a 50% tariff. The measure will apply to imports of steel products that can also be made in the UK," the UK said. London said that domestic steelmaking is essential to the resilience and security of the UK's critical national infrastructure and defence supply chains. "Like many other countries, the UK steel industry has been severely impacted by persistent global overcapacity," the UK said, indicating that the measures were primarily enforced to target China.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

AS GOVERNMENT READIES SHANTI ACT RULES

Special regulatory relaxations unlikely for small N-reactors

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, June 17

THE COUNTRY'S top atomic energy regulator is expected to maintain the same rigorous safety and licensing requirements for small modular reactors (SMRs) as those applicable to large nuclear reactors, *The Indian Express* has learned.

This comes even as SMRs are increasingly being pitched as a safer alternative to conventional reactors because of their advanced designs and passive safety systems. The government is currently readying the rules under the SHANTI Act, which opened up the country's tightly regulated civil nuclear sector to private participation.

With capacities ranging from 30 megawatt electric (MWe) to 300 MWe per unit, SMRs are being viewed as a promising option for decarbonising energy-intensive sectors such as steel, aluminium and cement, owing to their ability to produce large volumes of round-the-clock, low-carbon electricity.

The regulator's position is significant given the concerted push in the SHANTI Act to fostering private sector participation in the nuclear sector.

The need for stringent safety and licensing requirements have been considered necessary as most prospective domestic entrants in the sector lack experience in operating nuclear facilities.

The SHANTI Act, which received the assent of President on December 21, 2025, effectively allows private sector participation for the setting up a nuclear facility, or to carry out activities for the production, use and disposal of nuclear energy under a license from the Central Government and safety



SMRs are able to produce large volumes of round-the-clock, low-carbon electricity. REUTERS

authorisation of the country's nuclear regulator — the Atomic Energy Regulatory Board. To address this issue, the regulator views design support from the foreign or domestic technology providers as a precondition for granting licenses to any new entrants. Any company that seeks a license for a nuclear power plant has to have an agreement with a technology provider, from whom they are bringing the technology, to maintain the technology and train the operator to on operating parameters. In the absence of such an arrangement, no license would be given to any company, sources indicated to *The Indian Express*.

After a company secures a licence by establishing the required arrangements with the technology provider, the regulator will monitor compliance on an annual basis, including whether plant operators are receiving the necessary training from the technology provider.

The licensing framework is expected to remain the same for both SMRs and large reactors, notwithstanding the nascent state of India's SMR ecosystem and the domestic

policy push for these small reactors. India's nuclear power programme has so far been anchored by indigenous pressurised heavy water reactors (PHWRs), which use heavy water as both coolant and moderator and natural uranium as fuel. Even though PHWRs will continue to form the backbone of the country's nuclear expansion plans, SMRs are increasingly viewed as technology of promise that could help in industrial decarbonisation. SMRs are also becoming the focal point in India's international outreach for nuclear collaborations, with the high project costs of large light water reactors triggering questions about the feasibility of their large-scale deployment in India. Last month a visiting high-powered American nuclear delegation was informed, in their meetings with top government functionaries, of India's ambitions to progressively enter the manufacturing value chain of SMRs. It is learnt that India is actively seeking foreign expertise and investment to support the development of a domestic SMR ecosystem.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

RBI lifts interest rate ceiling on NRE & FCNR(B) deposits

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 17

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) has decided to temporarily withdraw interest rate restriction on non-resident external (NRE) deposits of 3 year and above tenors in a move aimed at attracting more capital inflows and stabilising the rupee.

The restriction with respect to interest rates offered on fresh NRE deposits mobilised by banks, including the deposits that are renewed upon maturity, for three years and above tenors, is temporarily withdrawn with effect from June 17, 2026, for the period until September 30, 2026, it said. "Any transfer from NRO accounts to NRE accounts shall not qualify for such exemption."

An NRE account allows a customer to deposit foreign currency, which is maintained in Indian rupees. It offers the benefit of allowing both principal and interest to be freely transferred abroad at any time. With the latest relaxation, banks are expecting more inflows through the NRE accounts as well, said a bank official.

Banks reported \$794 billion outstanding in 2025-26 under the NRE deposit scheme, according to RBI data. However, under the FCNR(B), the out-

• BOOSTING DEPOSITS

MOVE AIMED at attracting more capital inflows and stabilise the rupee

NRE ACCOUNT allows a customer to deposit foreign currency, which is maintained in Indian rupees, and offers the unique benefit of allowing both principal and interest to be freely transferred abroad at any time

CURRENTLY, INTEREST rates on non-resident external and NRO deposits should not be higher than those offered by the bank on



comparable domestic rupee term deposits

standing was only \$946 million in FY26.

On June 5, the RBI announced a concessional foreign exchange swap facility on FCNR(B) deposits until September 30, 2026 to encourage external commercial borrowings (ECBs) by public sector firms. At the core, the RBI is effectively lowering the hedging and funding cost of borrowing in foreign currency, enabling banks to raise cheaper funds abroad.

"The interest rate ceiling applicable to fresh FCNR(B) deposits mobilised by banks, including the deposits that are renewed upon maturity, for three years and above-up to and including five years tenors, is temporarily withdrawn with

effect from June 17, 2026, for the period until September 30, 2026," it said in a notification.

The relaxation includes NRE deposits that are renewed upon maturity, from the date of this Amendment Directions till September 30, 2026, the RBI said.

Banks have started offering higher interest rates on FCNR(B) deposits with many offering around 7% rate. "We estimate around \$30-50 billion of inflows from this scheme in CY26, all of which we expect to materialize by Q3 (July-September). Some state and private sector banks have already raised the FCNR (B) deposit rates by around 2-4%," Goldman Sachs said in a report.

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• ECONOMY

Food inflation may creep higher in coming months



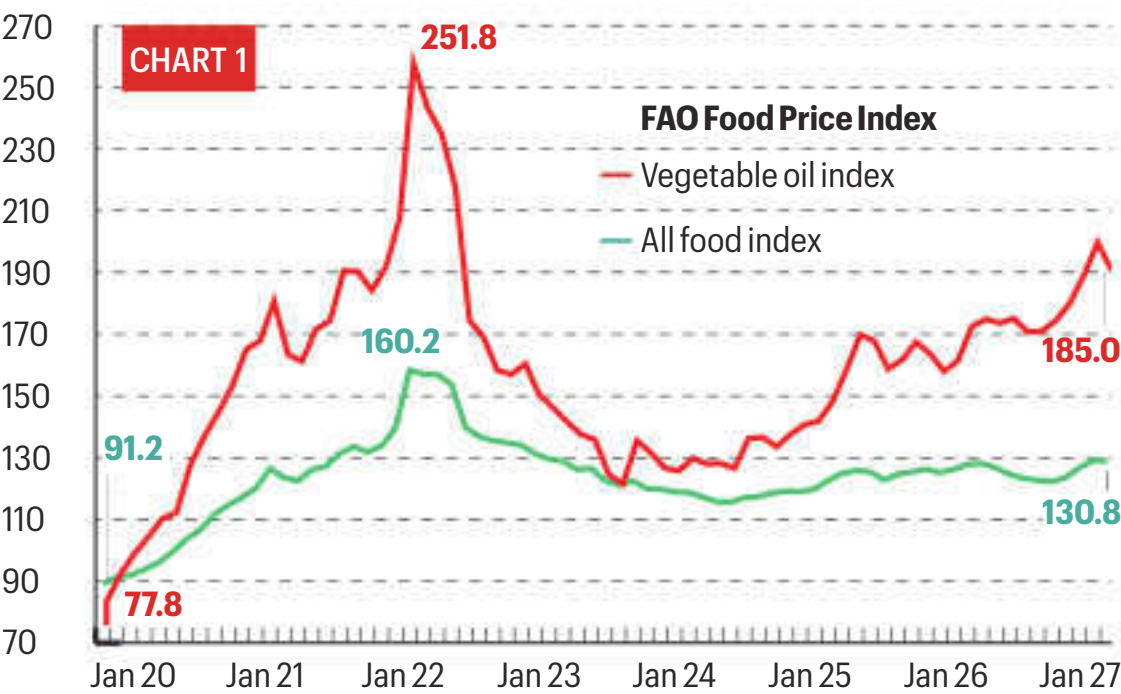
HARISH DAMODARAN

ON JUNE 11, the US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration declared that El Niño conditions have developed, forecasting a 62-63% probably of that turning into a “very strong” event during October-January. El Niño is an abnormal warming of the central and eastern Pacific Ocean waters off the coasts of Peru and Ecuador. It is associated with dry weather across India, Southeast Asia and Australia, while inducing heavy rain and destructive flooding in western Latin America, the US Gulf Coast and parts of the Caribbean. Sea surface temperatures in the east-central equatorial Pacific are currently 0.7 degrees Celsius above their 30-year-average. Any such deviation between 0.5 and 1 degrees is termed a “weak” El Niño. It is “moderate”, “strong” and “very strong” for deviations of 1-1.5 degrees, 1.5-2 degrees and above 2 degrees respectively.

What has been the impact on food prices?

This year is seeing El Niño make a return after 2023-24, when it was a “strong” event that lasted from June 2023 to April 2024. This year has also witnessed a massive energy supply shock from the US-Israel versus Iran war. The closure of the vital Strait of Hormuz waterway since February 28 has led to global fertiliser prices skyrocketing. In April-May, India contracted urea and di-ammonium phosphate imports at port-landed prices of \$935-959 and \$930-935 per tonne respectively, as against their corresponding year-ago levels of \$410-420 and \$700-725. But neither El Niño nor Iran has really affected global food prices so far. Export prices of wheat from Argentina, at \$237 per tonne, are marginally higher than the \$233 last year at this time, and flat for Russian (\$242) and European Union (\$229-231) grain. US and Brazilian corn export prices of \$205-208 per tonne, too, are only mildly up over last year’s \$200-201. Indian and Pakistani non-basmati rice is now being shipped out at \$340-380 per tonne, down from \$380-395 a year ago. It’s not just cereals. Raw sugar prices in New York, at 14.3 cents per pound, are below the 16.5 cents of a year ago. Prices of

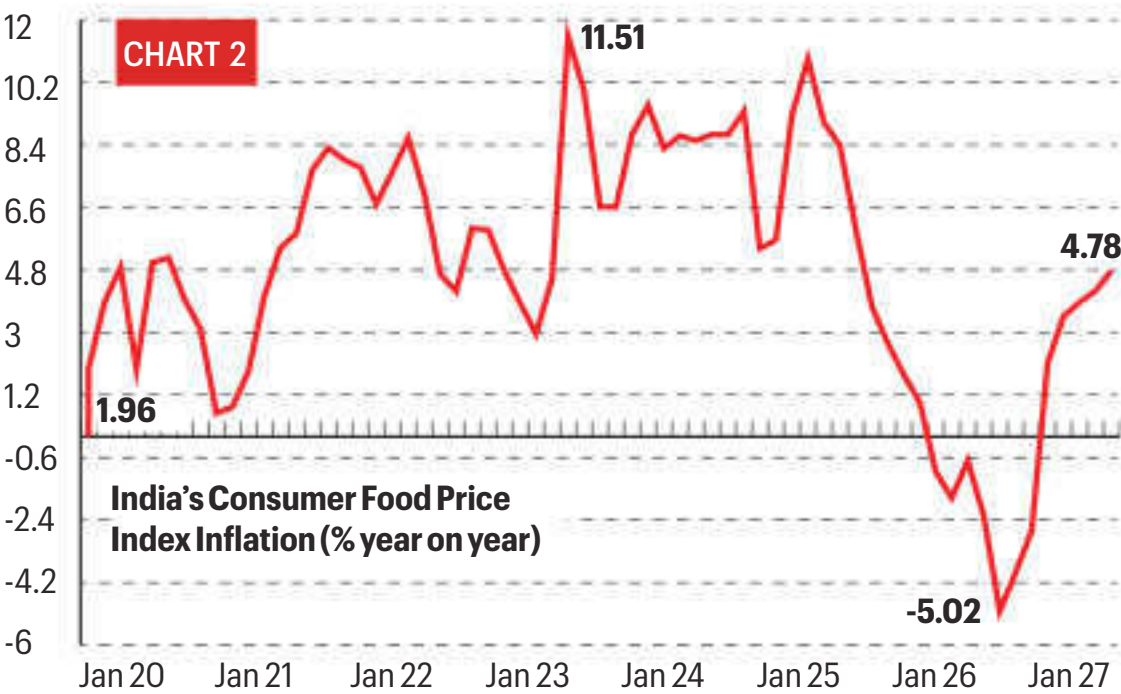
• Global food prices are lower than Ukraine war peak...



SOURCE: FOOD AND AGRICULTURE ORGANIZATION OF THE UNITED NATIONS

butter at New Zealand’s Global Dairy Trade fortnightly auction platform have eased from \$7,890 per tonne on June 17, 2025 to \$5,516 on June 16, 2026. All this is reflected in the UN Food and Agriculture Organization’s (FAO) food price index in May 2026 registering just a 2.9% increase over May 2025. The index — a weighted average of world prices of a basket of food commodities over a base period value (taken at 100 for 2014-16) — hit an all-time-high of 160.2 points in March 2022, immediately after Russia’s invasion of Ukraine. The latest reading of 130.8 points is nowhere near that peak. The behaviour of food prices is a contrast to energy and metals, where the effects of the West Asia conflict are clearly visible. The International Monetary Fund’s index for base metals (aluminium, cobalt, copper, iron ore, lead, molybdenum, nickel, tin, uranium and zinc) was 31.9% up in May 2026 over May 2025, while 44.5% for precious metals (gold, silver, palladium and platinum), 62.5% for crude petroleum, 27.9% for natural gas, 34.4% for coal and 24% for fertilisers. The only food commodity to have posted a notable price surge is vegetable oils. The FAO index for it, at 185 points in May, was 21.5% higher than a year ago, though below the 251.8-point high of March 2022 (see *chart 1*). Present landed prices of imported crude palm, soyabean and sunflower oil in Mumbai, at \$1,240, \$1,270 and \$1,440 per tonne, are above their corresponding June 2025 average levels of \$1,055, \$1,122 and \$1,209 respectively. A key reason for vegetable oil prices firm-

• ...but India’s food inflation is slowly edging up



SOURCE: NATIONAL STATISTICS OFFICE

ing up is their alternative use as biofuels. When global crude prices harden like they have, there is an additional incentive to divert palm, rapeseed and soyabean oil for the production of fatty acid methyl ester, which can substitute regular petroleum diesel. Why have food prices not soared despite Iran and El Niño? Mainly because of bumper crops in 2024-25 and 2025-26, which were both non-El Niño years. The US Department of Agriculture has estimated all-time record global output of 844.4 million tonnes (mt) for wheat, rice (544.7 mt), corn/maize (1,326.7 mt), sugar (186.1 mt) and even soyabean (429.2), rapeseed (95.6 mt) and palm oil (81.3 mt) in 2025-26. This situation of ample carryover stocks from back-to-back bumper harvests is unlike that in the run-up to the Russia-Ukraine war. From *chart 1*, one can see that the FAO food and vegetable oil indices were already rising from their May 2020 lows, following the demand recovery from the lifting of Covid-time lockdowns. Russia-Ukraine merely added fuel to the fire. India itself had a disastrous 2021-22 wheat crop. That, along with the 2023-24 El Niño, led to wheat stocks in government godowns depleting to 7.5 mt by April 1, 2004 – the lowest for that date since 2008. But the successive good crops of 2024-25 and 2025-26 helped rebuild those stocks to 21.8 mt on April 1 and 42.8 mt on May 1, 2026. In other words, the pre-war starting point for food has been less bad this time,

compared to Russia-Ukraine in 2022. But can there be food inflation down the line? That’s very much possible. The signs of it are there in India’s annual consumer food price index inflation edging up to 4.8% in May, from 4.2%, 3.9%, 3.5% and 2.1% in the preceding four months and negative rates over June-December 2025 (*chart 2*). India’s last episode of high food inflation was during July 2023 to December 2024, which was courtesy of the “strong” 2023-24 El Niño event. El Niño is known to not only suppress rainfall, but also raise temperatures. If this El Niño turns out to be a “super/very strong” and peak through October-January, it could result in a relatively short and warm winter. The rabi (winter-spring) crops are the ones that would bear the brunt. El Niño apart, agricultural production can also take a hit from fertiliser shortages due to the West Asia conflict. An offsetting factor here could be a US-Iran deal to end fighting and reopen the Hormuz maritime chokepoint — through which roughly a third of the globally traded fertiliser products transited before the West Asia war. The expectations from that alone have more than halved the import price (cost plus ocean freight) of urea in the most recent tender by India to \$444.9-449.3 per tonne. On balance, one cannot rule out higher food inflation in the months ahead. A lot depends on the El Niño’s intensity and duration as well as an early and meaningful restoration of global fertiliser flows.

• INFRASTRUCTURE

Bullet train tunnel ‘hoods’: What they are and why they matter

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, June 17

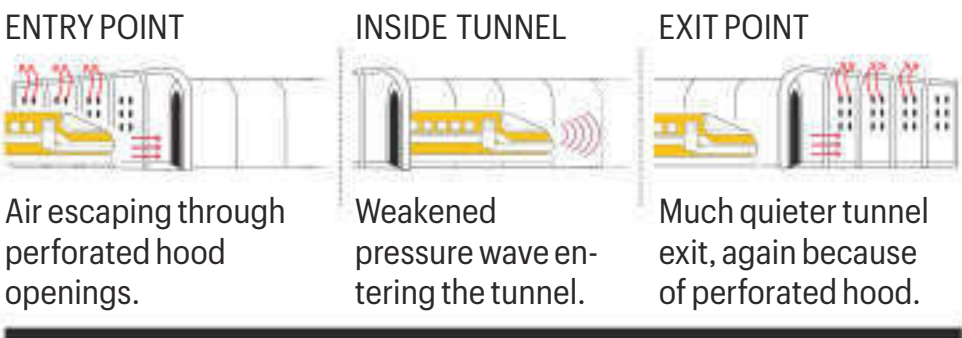
THE TUNNELS in India’s bullet train project will feature “hoods”, a first for the Indian Railways. Tunnel hoods are cylindrical structures that have pressure-relief vents or windows and are built at the entrance and exit of a tunnel. “It has been designed to mitigate the tunnel boom effect caused by pressure waves generated by high-speed trains,” said National High Speed Rail Corporation Ltd (NHSRCL), the implementing agency. The 508-km Mumbai-Ahmedabad High Speed Rail (MAHSR) project has seven mountain tunnels in Maharashtra and one mountain tunnel in Gujarat. Each tunnel will have “hoods” at both the entry and exit points. The entrance hood in Gujarat’s only tunnel in Valsad has taken shape and is nearing completion. This is the first time such tunnel hood technology has been designed and implemented for railway tunnels in India.

A common feature

Tunnel hoods are a common feature on high-speed rail systems in countries operating bullet trains, where trains travel at speeds exceeding 300 km per hour. Maharashtra’s bullet train tunnels are situated in Palghar district, where the alignment cuts through the difficult terrain of the Sahyadri mountains. Here, the tunnels replace viaducts (long, elevated bridges), and engineering becomes more complex. A senior NHSRCL official said that when a high-speed train enters a tunnel, it pushes a large volume of air ahead of it. “This sudden compression of air generates pressure waves that travel through the tunnel. If not properly managed, these pressure waves can create booming noise, similar to the explosion, when a train exits the tunnel,” the official said. “Tunnel hoods act as a transition zone between the open environment and the confined tunnel space. By allowing air to enter and exit more gradually, they help control pressure changes and improve the overall aerodynamic performance of the system.”

• How tunnel hood technology works

A hood is a perforated structure at a railway tunnel entrance. It helps high-speed trains enter and exit smoothly by reducing sudden air pressure buildup.



The role of windows

The windows in the tunnel hood help release this air pressure generated by the high-speed trains gradually. The number of windows varies from one tunnel to another. According to NHSRCL, the seven tun-

nels in Palghar will have tunnel hood wind-downs ranging from 20 to 26. Apart from this, the size of these hoods ranges from 31 metres to 45 m on each side, which increases the overall length of the tunnel. For instance, mountain tunnel no. 6 (MT-6) in Palghar is originally 390 m long, but the 32 m tunnel hoods with 20 windows on each side increase the total length of tunnel to 454 m. The work on this particular tunnel began on January 31, 2025, and breakthrough was achieved in 360 days. Breakthrough is a critical point when tunnels being excavated from both sides finally meet in the middle as per the alignment, ensuring continuous passage. A senior official of engineering and infrastructure major L&T, which is building bullet train mountain tunnels, told *The Indian Express* that entrance hood technology will upgrade India’s tunnel construction system. “In this, the overburden (total depth of soil and rock overlying the tunnel crown) was less, that is why it is challenging. The average excavation per day was 0.5 m to 1 m,” the L&T official said.